How Housedge is different, and how we defend it

Who else sells AI visibility, what they do and do not do, what is genuinely ours, and the plan to keep it ours. For the founders, 27 October 2026.

In one paragraph. Tracking what AI says about a brand is no longer special. Tools sell it from about $29 a month, Semrush and Ahrefs bundle it into plans their customers already pay for, and anyone can ask a chatbot once for free. If Housedge is "a dashboard of AI answers", it loses to whoever has more money. What we can own is the step after the dashboard:

- proof for every finding;
- a record of every action taken and what it changed;
- the work itself, done for the client;
- a growing dataset of what actually moves AI answers in the markets and industries we choose.

Sell the outcome ("AI names you when your customers ask, and here is the proof"), not the software.

> **"We get AI assistants to recommend you, and we prove it with every answer."**

1. Who else is selling this

TYPE	EXAMPLES AND PRICE	WHAT THEY GIVE	WHAT THEY DO NOT GIVE
Tracking tools	Otterly (from ~$29/mo), Peec AI (~$95–495/mo), Scrunch (~$250–300/mo; bought by Sitecore, June 2026), Profound (enterprise; entry tiers ~$99–399)	Daily tracking of your questions across ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Google AI; mention share; cited sources; some crawler analytics.	The work. They tell you where you stand; someone else has to change it. Peec is described as having no action layer at all.
SEO suites	Semrush AI Visibility Toolkit (~$99/mo per domain, in every Semrush One plan); Ahrefs Brand Radar (basic prompt tracking free in paid plans; full coverage ~$400–700/mo)	AI tracking as a tab next to SEO data their customers already use. Huge distribution.	Depth, service, industry focus. A tab, not a programme.
GEO agencies	$1,500–25,000/mo retainers; mid-market mostly $3,000–8,000/mo	Audit, schema, content rewrites, PR placements; usually 6–12 month engagements.	Their own measurement (they rent a tool); proof that their actions caused the change; prices most small and emerging-market brands cannot pay.

A chat	ChatGPT / Claude, free to $20/mo	A decent one-off audit and to-do list (we produced the Kays plan this way in under an hour, for $0.17).	Repeat measurement, sources over time, proof of change, execution.

Prices from vendor pages and third-party comparisons (see sources); they change often and should be checked before quoting them to a client.

2. What is genuinely ours, and what is not

CLAIM	STATUS	HONEST ASSESSMENT
Proof for every finding. Each brand found in an answer comes with the exact sentence from the answer; invented names are thrown out and counted.	**Built**	Most tools report counts and shares. We show the evidence per answer, which is what lets a marketing lead defend the numbers to a CFO, and lets our team check our own work in the admin console.
Work log: every action, dated, measured before vs after. A listing, a review campaign, a new page; AI answers compared 28 days before and after, with ranges, and whether AI started citing that page.	**Built (27 Oct)**	We found no tracking tool that records the client's interventions and measures each one. Agencies do it, if at all, in slides. This is the seed of the moat (section 3).
"What works" across all clients. The team-only table: for each kind of action, industry and market, how often it helped, by how much, how fast AI started citing it.	**Built, empty**	Worth nothing today, worth a lot after 20–30 clients in one vertical. Only exists if we log every action, every time.
Honest statistics. Ranges instead of single numbers; a change is "clear" only when the before and after ranges do not overlap.	**Partly**	Work log does this. The main dashboards still show single numbers; they should show ranges too.
Done for you, measured by us. The same team that changes things measures them.	**Service model**	Agencies do the work but rent measurement; tools measure but do not work. Doing both is the offer. It is a services business, by choice.
Fast, professional client set-up. Website read automatically, 9-step questionnaire, files, first check in minutes, automatic first report, client ratings.	**Built**	Lets a small team run many clients. Copyable, so it is an advantage, not a moat.

Emerging markets and regulated industries.	**Positioning**	Real but must be earned: local questions, local sources, compliance-safe wording. We already hit a market quirk the big tools may not handle: Claude's web search rejects Pakistan and Nigeria as locations; we now retry without the location so the answers still come back.
Tracking across AI assistants	**Behind**	Every competitor covers ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Google AI. We run Claude only today. This is table stakes; it must be fixed before we sell, not a differentiator.
Dashboards and charts	Equal	Good, but everyone has them. Not a reason to buy.

3. How we defend it

Ranked by how hard each one is for a competitor to copy.

#	DEFENCE	WHY IT HOLDS	WHAT IT TAKES
1	**The action → result dataset.** Every client action logged with its date, every result measured, pooled by industry and market.	Tools record outcomes, not interventions. Agencies have interventions but no consistent measurement. After 20–30 clients in a vertical, we know what moves AI answers there and how long it takes. A chat cannot know it, and a competitor cannot buy it. It also makes our to-do lists better than a chat's: "in Pakistani fintech, comparison-page listings were cited within 3 weeks in 7 of 10 cases".	Discipline: log every action, every client, every time (now one form in the Work log). Same method in every account.
2	**Sell the outcome, priced on it.** Monthly retainer for the work plus a bonus tied to measured mention share.	Software companies avoid services and outcome pricing; agencies avoid measurable promises. Our measurement makes the promise possible and the proof undeniable. It also locks in renewals: the client's own before/after history lives with us.	Clear baseline at onboarding (automatic first check), monthly report with ranges, a contract with a measurable target.
3	**Own a niche.** Fintech and money apps in emerging markets first (Kays: Pakistan, Nigeria), iGaming second (where the product started; big SEO suites tend to avoid it).	Generic tools optimise for US/EU English. The hard parts in our niche are local: the questions people really ask, the local listicles and forums AI reads, the regulatory language. Being "the AI-visibility people for fintech in emerging markets" beats being one of fifty for everyone.	Say no to off-niche clients for a while. Build the question library and source list per market.
4	**Relationships with the pages AI reads.**	In each niche a few dozen sites (comparison pages, review sites, communities, trade press) shape what AI says. An outreach network with them is slow to build and invisible in any competitor's feature list.	A publisher list per market (from our own citation data: which sites AI cites for our clients' questions), and a person who works it.
5	**Publish a monthly index.** "AI visibility: money apps in Pakistan" from our own tracking.	PR, lead generation (every low-ranked brand is a prospect), and proof of method in one. Makes us the reference in the niche; the data is ours.	Track the top 20–30 brands of the niche on a fixed question set; publish monthly.

6	**Price below agencies.** €1,500/mo against $3,000–8,000 mid-market.	Possible because the software does the measuring and reporting an agency does by hand. Opens the emerging-market and start-up segment agencies cannot serve.	Keep AI costs low (Sonnet for Run now, Opus batch for scheduled checks, Haiku for reading: about $1.30 for a 17-question check).

Not defences. More dashboard features, more charts, more engines than the next tool, or a lower software price. These are where the funded tools and the SEO suites win. Match them where it is table stakes (engine coverage), then stop.

4. Where we are exposed

THREAT	RESPONSE
Semrush and Ahrefs make basic AI tracking free inside plans people already have.	Do not sell tracking. Sell outcomes and proof; our clients may well keep their Semrush.
Funded tools (Profound, Peec) add an "action layer" or partner with agencies.	Speed and niche: be first and deepest in our markets, with the dataset and the publisher relationships they would have to build from zero.
AI companies open official brand channels (shopping feeds, merchant programmes, ads in assistants).	An opportunity as much as a threat: be the team that uses those channels for clients the day they open. The work log will measure them like any other action.
A client asks a chat for the audit and does the work in-house.	Fine for the one-off plan. They still need repeat measurement, proof over time, and the work done well; our niche data makes our plan better than the chat's.
We are a services business, so we scale with people.	Accept it early; the software keeps the team small per client. Productise later from the dataset (for example self-serve plans with recommendations learned from real results).

5. Next 90 days

PRODUCT	BUSINESS

1. **Connect ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity** (needs their API keys). Table stakes.
2. **Weekly scheduled checks** with Opus at half price (batch).
3. **"Pages you are missing from"**: from citation data, list the sites AI cites for the client's questions where the client is absent. It becomes the to-do list, with evidence.
4. **Ranges on every dashboard number**, not only in the Work log.
5. **Memory vs search**: show per answer whether the assistant searched (we already store it); the fixes differ.
6. **One click from a suggested action to a Work log entry**, so logging is effortless.

1. Pick the niche: fintech in Pakistan and Nigeria, starting with Kays.
2. Sign 3–5 design clients on retainer plus outcome bonus, at a launch price.
3. Log every action from day one; first "what works" table by month 3.
4. Build the publisher list per market from our own citation data.
5. Publish the first monthly index.
6. Write the Kays case study once there is a before/after.

Sources: vendor pricing as summarised by Ryze, RankPrompt, SEO Stuff, Surmado, Stork (Scrunch/Sitecore), Rework (Semrush and Ahrefs); agency pricing from upGrowth, Nutshell, DemandLocal, First Pier. Many are vendor-written; treat prices as indicative. Housedge facts from the app and tests as of 27 October 2026.